

1720–1770

BAROQUE TO NEOCLASSICAL

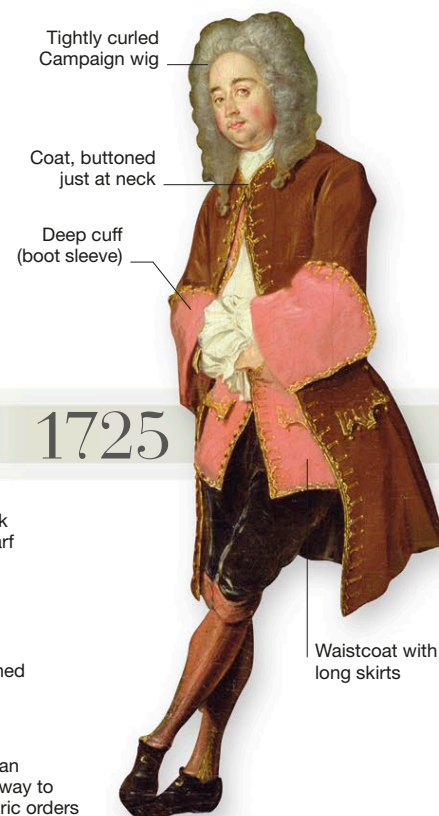
France was the centre of fashion in the 18th century and dressing well was seen as the cornerstone of an established society. France had the finest textile industries, and throughout the salons of Paris, and Europe, clothes were the visible elements of social standing. It was English country dress, however, that became increasingly important as the century progressed. Fashions changed slowly, but there was an awareness of slight nuances, such as new styles in silk design or a change in the length of waistcoats. The components of men's dress remained constant – an outer garment, waistcoat, and breeches – but the look changed across the century from the heavy baroque through the lighter rococo to the beginnings of the neoclassical. By the end of the period there was a new garment called the frock, which was based on English sporting dress.



Old style This man wears a bob wig, a style that was going out of fashion at this date. His suit, with its deep cuffs and its coat and waistcoat made of the same wool cloth, is old fashioned.



Summer shades Full suits (matching coats and breeches) in colourful tints were worn as formal dress at European courts, with pink silks and satins a popular summer choice. Men switched to heavier suits of patterned silk velvet in winter.



Bulky cuffs In early 18th-century Europe there was a baroque heaviness in the style of fashionable menswear, exemplified by the oversized turn-back cuffs on a man's coat, which reached almost to the elbow.



Grand tour Wealthy men travelled to Italy to study classical antiquity and to experience polite society. An appreciation of fine dressing was part of gracious living. This man wears an embroidered matching silk coat and waistcoat.